



What are the different ways government can contract for community mobilization (community action versus community development)?

In their desire to have outcomes achieved, government agencies, philanthropies or other funders may decide to fund community mobilization where providers of one sort or another are contracted to work with communities to bring about change. There are two types of broad strategies that can be contracted for.

The first type is called Community Action - where a government agency or other funder funds a provider to take action with a community on a specific topic - e.g. alcohol, drugs, nutrition. The funding is allocated with a specific purpose in mind, and the outcomes of the initiative are not open-ended. This work is sometimes argued for under the third and fourth rationale in the Determining Whose Outcomes - Citizen or Government's - The Rationales for Government Assistance Framework Tool (B20). The second is Community Development - funding provided for the community to define its own outcomes and work on improving them in whatever way it wants to. In this case, the community is able to decide on the outcomes it wants to improve and the strategies it wants to use to improve them.

These two modes of working with communities do not need to be in conflict. In an ideal world, they can both operate within a single community. Given that the outcomes being selected in both types of initiatives will likely be for the social good, a Community Development initiative can incorporate, or work alongside, a Community Action initiative focused on a topic that it supports.

However, when funding and contracting for such programs, to avoid misunderstanding, it's important for all stakeholders to be clear about which way of working is being used in a particular case and drawing the DoView strategy/ outcomes diagram for an initiative can assist with this. It will clearly capture and communicate the outcomes for the initiative and the steps it's believed will lead to them. The DoView diagram can then be used to identify the outcomes that need to be evaluated in any such community initiative. Obviously, a Community Action initiative that did not achieve any of the outcomes in the topic area would not be successful, and a Community Development initiative in which the community did not get to determine its outcomes would be evaluated as unsuccessful.